centres in which this tendency has not manifested itself fully or has only just insinuated itself' (Marini 1992:138). 'Sub-imperialism's historical materialisation is not merely a question of economics. The existence of the right conditions for its development is not guaranteed only by the transformation of a country into a sub-imperialist centre … In this sense, in our days [it] is Brazil [that] can be identified as the purest manifestation of sub-imperialism' (Marini 2012:41).

Conclusion

As we have tried to sustain in our analysis, Marini's category of sub-imperialism conveys a totality formed by different levels of abstraction. Confusion about these different levels of analysis or abstraction – taking the historical determinations of only one or some of them – is at the origin of many incorrect interpretations of his proposed category. As an historical phenomenon, sub-imperialism undergoes varied forms while conserving its very essence. Ignoring these two premises has given rise to many of the mistaken interpretations surrounding the concept developed by Marini.

Obviously it is much easier to point to the gaps in an analysis that is embryonic than to follow the path Marini inaugurated and to further his investigation. But selecting the first option can mean pushing a theory backwards. By contrast our option has been to show that in Marini there are the basic elements for a global theory of sub-imperialism and that it is from them that we are able to explain with due rigour the present expansionist trend of Brazilian capitalism and its foreign policy; for example, the mergers and acquisitions involving multinationals with Brazilian capital, the control over other Latin American or African countries' raw materials and energy sources, or the military occupation of Haiti.

Analyses that overestimate capitalism's and the Brazilian state's autonomy as well as those that neglect its relative autonomy within the boundaries of sub-imperialism misunderstand the significance of sub-imperialism. For the former, sub-imperialism does not make sense because it is supposed to be a mere channel of communication for the dominant imperialism. For those who adhere to the latter perspective, the category is not sustainable because it implies the notion of a second-rank imperialism. Neither connotation corresponds to the concept of sub-imperialism whose true meaning we hope to have helped restore in the course of this chapter.

Accordingly it is possible to affirm that Brazil in Latin America, South Africa in Southern Africa, Israel in the Middle East and India in Southeast Asia are examples, today, of sub-imperialist countries, whose power structures and logic demand a rigorous analysis without forgoing their complex categorial network.